Pallava Genealogy (Prominent Kings)

There were early Pallava rulers who were feudatories of Satavahanas. Simhavishnu, son of Simhavarman II (around 550 AD (CE), created a strong Pallava kingdom after destroying the Kalabhras. He defeated many kings in the south including the Cholas and the Pandyas. His able son was Mahendravarman I. He was succeeded by his son Narasimhavarman I. The other prominent Pallava rulers were Narasimhavarman II or Rajasimha and Nandivarman II. The last Pallava ruler was Aparajita.

Mahendravarman (*c.*600–630AD (CE)) contributed to the greatness of the Pallava kingdom. Mahendravarman I was a follower of Jainism in the early part of his rule. He embraced Saivism by the Saivite saint Appar (Tirunavukkarasar). He was a great patron of art and architecture. He is known for introducing a new style to Dravidian architecture, which is referred to as 'Mahendra style'. Mahendravarman also wrote plays, including (*c.*620) *MattavilasaPrahasana.* (*The Delight of the Drunkards*) in Sanskrit, which denigrates Buddhism.

Mahendravarman's reign involved constant battles with the Western Chalukya kingdom of Badami under Pulakesin II. Pulakesin seems to have defeated Mahendravarman in one of the battles and taken over a large part of his territory (Vengi) in the north. His son Narasimavarma I (c. 630–668) avenged the defeat by capturing Vatapi, the capital of Chalukyas. He set Vatapi on fire, killing Pulakesin in the process.

Narasimhavarman I's army general was Paranjothi. Popularly known as Siruthondar (one of the 63 Nayanmars), Paranjothi led the Pallava army during the invasion of Vatapi. After the victory he had a change of heart and devoted himself to Lord Siva

–Periya Puranam

Narasimhavarman II (c. 695–722), also known as Rajasimha, was a great military strategist. He exchanged ambassadors with China. His reign was comparatively free from any political disturbance. Therefore, he could concentrate on temple-building activities. During his reign, the famous Kailasanatha temple at Kanchipuram was built.

Name of the King	Title/s Adopted
Simhavishnu	Avanisimha
Mahendravarma I	Sankirnajati Mattavilasa Gunabhara Chitrakarapuli Vichitra Chitta
Narasimhavarma I	Mamallan, Vatapi Kondan

Pallava's Contribution to Architecture

Pallava period is known for architectural splendour. The Shore Temple and various other temples carved from granite monoliths and the Varaha cave (7th century) at Mamallapuram, are illustrious examples of Pallava architecture. In 1984, Mamallapuram was added to the list of UNESCO World Heritage Sites.

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